‘Their submission to their superiors was great, but they executed deference from those under them with a cruelty and arrogance rarely practised but among Hindus in their state of independence. A Nair was expected instantly to cut down a Tiar, or Musua who presumed to defile him by touching his person; and a similar fate awaited a slave who did not turn out of the road as a Nair passed.’

But what most intrigued Buchanan about these Nairs was not their arrogance but their unconventional customs, enshrined in the practice known as *sambandham*. ‘The Nairs marry before they are ten years of age … but the husband never afterwards cohabits with his wife,’ is how Buchanan begins his account of the Nairs’ highly unusual management of their private lives, which included their women extending their favours to Nambudiri Brahmins and others of high rank:

> It is no kind of reflection on a woman’s character to say, that she has formed the closest intimacy with many persons: on the contrary, the Nair women are proud of reckoning among their favoured lovers many Brahmans, Rajas, and other persons of high birth … In consequence of this strange manner of propagating the species, no Nair knows his father; and every man looks upon his sisters’ children as his heirs … A man’s mother manages his family; and after her death his eldest sister assumes the direction. Even cousins, to the most remote degree of kindred, in the female line, generally live together in great harmony; for in this part of the country love, jealousy or disgust never can disturb the peace of a Nair family.

For Nair women, *sambandham* with Nambudiris and royalty was a matter of prestige and enhanced social status. Even so, when Buchanan’s three-volume account of his survey was published in 1807, his description of the sexual